University of Ottawa
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Organizational Readiness for Agentic AI Adoption in Digital Transformation: A Literature Review

Assignment 3: Final Literature Review Report

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1. Introduction

Organizations continue to invest heavily in digital transformation, and artificial intelligence (AI) has become one of its central drivers (Vial, 2019; Verhoef et al., 2021). A newer class of systems, usually called agentic AI, raises the stakes further. Agentic AI refers to software agents that pursue goals, plan multi-step actions, and act with limited human supervision (Acharya et al., 2025). Unlike earlier AI tools that produce a prediction for a person to act on, agents can initiate actions, take responsibility for loosely defined tasks, and work under uncertainty (Baird & Maruping, 2021). This shift changes what it means for an organization to be "ready" for AI.

The research problem is that most readiness guidance still treats AI adoption as a technology checklist covering data, infrastructure, and models. Yet many AI projects fail to deliver value even when the technology works (Schmidt et al., 2026; Enholm et al., 2022). The literature on organizational AI readiness is growing (Jöhnk et al., 2021; Holmström, 2022), but it was largely developed before agentic systems appeared. It is therefore unclear whether existing readiness factors are sufficient when organizations begin to delegate decisions and actions, not only analysis, to software agents.

This question matters for both research and practice. For researchers, it tests whether established constructs such as readiness for change (Weiner, 2009) and AI capability (Mikalef & Gupta, 2021) still hold when the technology itself has agency. For managers, it affects where to invest first: in technology, in people and processes, or in the governance needed to supervise autonomous systems.

The purpose of this review is to synthesize peer-reviewed literature on organizational AI readiness, agentic and autonomous systems, and digital transformation in order to answer one primary research question: **What organizational readiness factors most influence whether firms can successfully adopt agentic AI as part of digital transformation?** Two subquestions guide the analysis: (a) How do culture, structure, and skills shape the implementation and outcomes of autonomous AI agents? (b) What governance and change-management practices support or hinder the safe delegation of decisions to agents? The scope is limited to organization-level studies published mainly between 2018 and 2026, with a small number of earlier foundational works.

The report is organized as follows. Section 2 describes the review methods. Section 3 presents the synthesis in three themes: readiness dimensions, the distinctive features of agentic systems, and transformation governance and change management. Section 4 answers the research question, discusses implications and gaps, and concludes.

2. Methods

Type of review. This study is a structured narrative (integrative) literature review. It uses a documented, reproducible search but does not aim to be a full systematic review. An integrative approach suits the topic because agentic AI is new and the relevant evidence is spread across information systems, management, and human–automation research, using very different methods.

Databases and search terms. Searches were run in two academic databases, OpenAlex and Semantic Scholar, on 15 September 2026. The search strings combined four concepts and their synonyms: organizational readiness (readiness, preparedness), agentic AI (agentic AI, AI agents, autonomous AI), digital transformation (digitalization), and adoption. Table 1 summarizes the main searches. A supplementary search in October 2026 added sources on delegation, decision-making structures, and AI governance. It used targeted OpenAlex and Semantic Scholar queries (e.g., "agentic" AND "delegation"; "AI governance" AND organization*), the AIS eLibrary, and backward citation chasing from Jöhnk et al. (2021) and Enholm et al. (2022). Citation chasing also identified the foundational works on readiness for change and levels of automation.

Table 1. *Summary of database searches*

Database	Search query	Filters	Results	Main contribution
OpenAlex	"AI readiness" AND "digital transformation" (title/abstract)	Journal articles; 2018+; English	146	Core readiness and DT studies
OpenAlex	"agentic AI" AND readiness (title/abstract)	2022+; all types	377	Recent agentic-AI work, incl. HICSS 2026
Semantic Scholar	organizational readiness artificial intelligence adoption	2018–2026	9,528	Coverage check; adoption studies
OpenAlex / Semantic Scholar / AIS eLibrary (supplementary)	"agentic" AND delegation; "AI governance" AND organization*; backward citation chasing	Peer-reviewed; 2018+ (foundational works exempt)	—	Delegation, governance, and foundational works

Note. Search date for the first three searches: 15 September 2026. Full query log is in the literature review catalogue (Assignment 1).

Inclusion and exclusion criteria. Sources were included if they were peer-reviewed journal articles or conference papers, written in English, published from 2018 to 2026, and relevant to organizational readiness, AI or agentic-AI adoption, or digital transformation. Foundational works published before 2018 were included only when later studies repeatedly built on them. Non-peer-reviewed items (industry reports, blogs, white papers), purely technical AI papers without an organizational angle, and non-English publications were excluded.

Screening and selection. Results were sorted by relevance. Titles were screened first, then abstracts, and finally full texts for the remaining candidates. The broad Semantic Scholar search (9,528 results) was used to check coverage rather than read in full: screening stopped once new results mostly repeated sources that had already been found. Each source was verified through its DOI or the publisher's page before inclusion. The final set contains **24 peer-reviewed sources: 21 journal articles and 3 conference papers** (HICSS 2020, ECIS 2019, HICSS 2026). It includes conceptual, review, qualitative, quantitative, simulation, and mixed-methods studies. Four works are treated as seminal or foundational: Armenakis et al. (1993), Parasuraman et al. (2000), Weiner (2009), and Vial (2019).

Information extraction and synthesis. For each source, a literature catalogue recorded the research aim, form of inquiry, reasoning, method, a summary, verbatim evidence excerpts with page locations, limitations, and the related theme. Themes were first drafted inductively from the catalogue and then refined as new sources were added. A concept matrix (Table 2) maps each source to the subthemes and records its type of evidence. The matrix was used to compare sources within each theme, identify agreement and contradiction, and locate thinly covered areas.

3. Literature Review

3.1 Theme 1: Readiness is multidimensional, and technology is the smallest part

The first clear pattern is broad agreement that AI readiness is not mainly technical. Jöhnk et al. (2021) identify readiness factors in five categories: strategic alignment, resources, knowledge, culture, and data. Pumplun et al. (2019), using the technology–organization–environment (TOE) lens, also find that organizational factors sit alongside technical ones. Holmström (2022) and Uren and Edwards (2023) propose readiness frameworks that likewise extend beyond technology, the latter adding data to the classic people–process–technology view. These studies use different designs (expert interviews, conceptual framework building), yet they converge, which strengthens the conclusion. All of them, however, describe conventional AI rather than agentic AI, so they should be read as the base layer of readiness rather than the full picture.

3.1.1 Technological and data readiness

Data appears in almost every readiness framework (see the T1a column in Table 2). Uren and Edwards (2023) treat data as a separate readiness dimension, and Hradecky et al. (2022) show that

data management and protection can either drive or block adoption in the exhibition sector. The agentic-AI literature sharpens this point. Schmidt et al. (2026) argue that agents act on business processes, so readiness depends on how well processes are documented. They call the gap between documented and actual work "process debt". A predictive model can tolerate messy processes because a person interprets its output. An agent that executes a process cannot. This suggests that data and process readiness matter more for agentic AI than for earlier AI, although so far the claim rests on a single case.

3.1.2 Organizational capability and skills

A second point of agreement is that capability is built, not bought. Mikalef and Gupta (2021) show in a survey study that AI capability combines tangible resources (data, technology), human resources (technical and business skills), and intangible resources (coordination across departments, capacity for change, and risk proclivity), and that this capability is linked to creativity and firm performance. Alsheibani et al. (2020) similarly argue that the availability of AI expertise is part of readiness, and Enholm et al. (2022) find skills and top-management involvement among the most frequently reported enablers of AI value. Sturm et al. (2021) add an important nuance: in their simulations, organizations learned best when human learning was coordinated with machine learning rather than replaced by it. For agentic AI, this implies that the relevant skills include not only building agents but also supervising, correcting, and learning alongside them. A caution is that most capability evidence is cross-sectional (Mikalef & Gupta, 2021), so causal direction remains uncertain.

3.1.3 Cultural readiness and change mindset

The cultural dimension links the AI literature to older change-management theory. Armenakis et al. (1993) define readiness as people's beliefs that change is needed and that the organization can carry it out. Weiner (2009) refines this into two parts: change commitment (wanting to change) and change efficacy (believing the change can succeed). Jöhnk et al. (2021) explicitly build on this tradition, and Mikalef and Gupta's (2021) "risk proclivity" captures a similar idea. Empirical adoption studies support the importance of employee attitudes: Chatterjee et al. (2020) find that perceived usefulness and ease of use shape employees' intention to adopt AI systems, with leadership support as a moderator. Together, this work suggests that agentic AI may test culture more than earlier AI did, because employees are asked to trust a system that acts rather than one that only advises. Although many sources mention culture (Table 2, T1c), none measures it in an agentic setting, and the foundational change theories predate AI.

3.2 Theme 2: What makes agentic AI different is delegation

The second theme explains why conventional readiness frameworks may be insufficient. Berente et al. (2021) describe AI in terms of autonomy, learning, and inscrutability, and argue that managing AI means managing all three together. Baird and Maruping (2021) go further, proposing delegation as the core relationship between people and "agentic IS artifacts". In their framework, delegation depends on the agents' endowments, preferences, and roles, and works through appraisal, distribution, and coordination. Acharya et al. (2025) describe agentic AI as goal-directed and adaptive, and list goal alignment and adaptation to changing environments as open challenges. Read together, these sources move the readiness question from "Can we use AI?" to "Can we delegate to AI responsibly?"

3.2.1 Autonomy and control mechanisms

The literature agrees that autonomy is a matter of degree and that the right degree depends on the task. Parasuraman et al. (2000), a foundational work in human–automation research, separate automation into stages (acquiring information, analysing it, selecting a decision, and implementing an action) and show that each stage can be automated to a different level. Shrestha et al. (2019) apply a similar logic to organizations, describing full delegation to AI, hybrid sequences of human and AI decisions, and aggregated decision-making, and linking the choice to features of the decision such as its specificity and interpretability. Raisch and Krakowski (2021) add that

automation and augmentation form a paradox: over-emphasizing either one creates negative cycles. Here the sources partly disagree. Shrestha et al. (2019) treat the choice of structure as a design decision that managers can optimise, while Raisch and Krakowski (2021) argue that the tension can only be managed over time, never resolved. For agentic AI, both views suggest that readiness includes the ability to set and adjust levels of autonomy, not just to switch an agent on.

3.2.2 Agent capabilities and performance limits

Evidence on what agents can actually do in organizations remains limited. Acharya et al. (2025) survey applications in areas such as healthcare and finance but note persistent problems with alignment and reliability. Sturm et al. (2021) show that machine learning performs well in stable environments but that human input remains necessary when conditions change. Parasuraman et al. (2000) also warn of human costs of high automation, such as complacency and loss of skill. This subtheme is among the least covered in the matrix (Table 2, T2b, seven sources), and only one of those sources studies agentic systems inside a real organization (Schmidt et al., 2026). The rest are conceptual, review-based, simulation-based, or about earlier forms of AI.

3.3 Theme 3: Governance and change management turn readiness into adoption

The third theme connects readiness to outcomes. Vial (2019) shows that digital transformation is shaped as much by organizational barriers, such as inertia and resistance, as by technology. Verhoef et al. (2021) describe transformation as moving from digitization through digitalization to full transformation, with each stage requiring more flexible structures and new capabilities. Agentic AI arguably belongs at the most advanced stage, because it changes not only processes but also who, or what, makes decisions.

3.3.1 Transformation governance and strategy

Strategic alignment and top-management support appear consistently as readiness factors (Jöhnk et al., 2021; Enholm et al., 2022; Alsheibani et al., 2020). The newer governance literature adds detail on how to steer AI. Papagiannidis et al. (2025) find responsible AI governance research fragmented and organize it into structural, relational, and procedural practices. For agentic systems, governance must also assign accountability for actions an agent takes on its own, a question that Berente et al. (2021) and Baird and Maruping (2021) raise but do not resolve empirically. Holmström (2022) and Schmidt et al. (2026) both offer assessment tools, but neither has been tested on many organizations.

3.3.2 Change management and adoption practices

Studies of how organizations actually deploy AI emphasise process change and people. Wamba-Taguimdje et al. (2020), drawing on many AI projects, conclude that firms gain performance from AI only when they reconfigure their processes. Chatterjee et al. (2021) find that organizational agility and leadership support help explain adoption of AI-integrated systems, and Chatterjee et al. (2020) report similar results at the employee level. These studies share a limitation: they measure adoption intention or perceived benefit, mostly in one country (India) and one system type (CRM), rather than long-term outcomes. The two Chatterjee studies also come from overlapping author teams, so they are treated here as corroborating rather than independent evidence. Armenakis et al. (1993) provide practical levers that remain relevant, namely persuasive communication, active participation, and managing information from outside sources. However, no reviewed study tests these levers in an agentic-AI rollout.

3.4 Synthesis across themes

Table 2 makes three patterns visible. First, coverage counts look fairly even, with governance and strategy (T3a) the most covered and agent performance (T2b) and change management (T3b) the least. Counts alone, however, hide the second and more important pattern: the type of evidence differs systematically by theme. Readiness and adoption findings come mostly from interviews and surveys, while almost all agent-specific claims are conceptual, review-based, or from simulations; the only empirical agentic-readiness study is a single case (Schmidt et al., 2026). Third, the sources

that bridge themes, such as Schmidt et al. (2026), Berente et al. (2021), and Jöhnk et al. (2021), share an emphasis on processes and decision rights, which suggests that delegation is the concept connecting readiness to agentic adoption.

Table 2. *Concept matrix: sources by subtheme and type of evidence*

Source	Evidence	T1a	T1b	T1c	T2a	T2b	T3a	T3b
Armenakis et al. (1993)*	C			●				●
Parasuraman et al. (2000)*	C				●	●		
Weiner (2009)*	C			●				●
Vial (2019)*	R			●			●	●
Shrestha et al. (2019)	C				●		●	
Pumplun et al. (2019) [conf.]	Qual	●	●	●				
Alsheibani et al. (2020) [conf.]	Quant	●	●				●	
Wamba-Taguimdje et al. (2020)	Case					●	●	●
Chatterjee, Nguyen et al. (2020)	Quant			●				●
Jöhnk et al. (2021)	Qual	●	●	●			●	
Raisch & Krakowski (2021)	C				●		●	
Mikalef & Gupta (2021)	Quant	●	●	●				
Chatterjee, Chaudhuri et al. (2021)	Quant			●				●
Sturm et al. (2021)	Sim		●		●	●		
Verhoef et al. (2021)	C		●				●	
Baird & Maruping (2021)	C				●	●		
Berente et al. (2021)	C				●	●	●	
Holmström (2022)	C	●					●	
Enholm et al. (2022)	R	●	●				●	
Hradecky et al. (2022)	Qual	●		●				
Uren & Edwards (2023)	Qual	●	●					●
Acharya et al. (2025)	R				●	●		
Papagiannidis et al. (2025)	R				●		●	
Schmidt et al. (2026) [conf.]	Mixed (1 case)	●			●	●	●	
Coverage (number of sources)		**9**	**8**	**9**	**9**	**7**	**12**	**7**

Note. T1a = technological and data readiness; T1b = capability and skills; T1c = culture and change mindset; T2a = agent autonomy and control; T2b = agent capabilities and performance; T3a = governance and strategy; T3b = change management and adoption. Evidence: C = conceptual; R = review; Qual = qualitative interviews; Quant = survey; Case = multiple case analysis; Sim = simulation; Mixed = mixed methods. * = seminal or foundational work; [conf.] = conference paper.

4. Discussion and Conclusion

4.1 Response to the research question

The evidence suggests that successful agentic-AI adoption depends on two layers of readiness. The **base layer** consists of factors that are well supported for AI in general: strategic alignment and top-management support, data quality and availability, AI capability built from technical and business skills plus cross-functional coordination, and a culture with commitment to and confidence in

change (Jöhnk et al., 2021; Mikalef & Gupta, 2021; Weiner, 2009). The **agentic layer** consists of what this review calls delegation readiness: well-documented processes with little process debt, explicit decisions about the level of autonomy for each task, oversight and override mechanisms, and governance that assigns accountability for agent actions (Schmidt et al., 2026; Baird & Maruping, 2021; Parasuraman et al., 2000; Papagiannidis et al., 2025). The base layer appears necessary but not sufficient. On current evidence, the most influential factors are strategic alignment, data and process readiness, and capability, because they have the strongest empirical support. Delegation readiness is the factor most specific to agentic AI, but its support is still largely conceptual.

For subquestion (a), culture, structure, and skills matter mainly through how people relate to delegated work: whether employees trust and can supervise agents, whether structures allow flexible decision rights, and whether skills are developed alongside the technology (Sturm et al., 2021; Verhoef et al., 2021). For subquestion (b), practices that appear to support safe delegation include staged autonomy matched to the decision type, human-in-the-loop checkpoints, and structural, relational, and procedural governance (Shrestha et al., 2019; Papagiannidis et al., 2025). Practices that appear to hinder it include treating adoption as a technology rollout and over-automating without managing the automation–augmentation tension (Raisch & Krakowski, 2021; Vial, 2019).

4.2 Implications

For practice, the findings suggest that organizations should assess process documentation and decision rights before deploying agents, rather than starting from model selection. Readiness assessments based on conventional AI may give a false sense of preparedness for agentic systems. For research, the findings suggest that readiness models should add a delegation dimension that builds on established theory (Baird & Maruping, 2021; Parasuraman et al., 2000) rather than inventing new constructs.

4.3 Gaps, limitations, and future research

Three gaps stand out. First, there is little empirical evidence on agentic deployments in real organizations, and the key study is a single case in one German university (Schmidt et al., 2026). Second, cultural readiness has rarely been measured in agentic settings. Third, adoption studies mostly measure intention, in narrow contexts, at one point in time. The literature itself is also limited by a strong reliance on cross-sectional and single-context designs. This review has limitations of its own: it used two main databases plus citation chasing, included only English-language peer-reviewed work, and was carried out by a single reviewer, so screening and theme coding may reflect individual judgement. Future research could (1) run multi-case or longitudinal studies of agentic-AI deployments, (2) develop and validate a measure of delegation readiness, and (3) test whether established change-management levers work when the change involves autonomous agents.

4.4 Conclusion

This review finds broad agreement that AI readiness is multidimensional and mostly organizational. Agentic AI does not replace these factors but adds a new demand: the ability to delegate decisions and actions to software agents safely and accountably. The literature describes this demand well in conceptual terms but has barely begun to test it empirically. Closing that gap is the main task for future research on agentic AI in digital transformation.

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